

Frequently Asked Questions:

November Special Town Meeting & District Priorities

Academic Priorities & Class Sizes

Q: You mentioned our class sizes are "far above optimal." Why aren't we using this new funding to hire more general education teachers and reduce class sizes?

A: We share your frustration regarding class sizes. As parents and educators, our instinct is always that fewer students per room equals better outcomes. However, the math of our current budget reality prevents this. Even if we receive the maximum projected state revenue, dividing those funds to hire general education teachers would not allow us to reduce class size across all elementary grades.

Q: If we can't make classes small, how does hiring Reading Specialists fix the problem?

A: Educational research, including comprehensive meta-analyses by researchers like John Hattie, shows that simply reducing a class from 30 students to 25 does not significantly change student outcomes unless the teacher drastically alters their instructional method. However, intensive, targeted intervention by a specialized reading teacher has one of the highest effect sizes in education—specifically, it is shown to be 8 to 15 times more effective at improving literacy than minor class size reductions. By hiring specialists, we guarantee that students who are struggling receive dedicated, small-group expert instruction that a classroom teacher cannot provide to a room of 25+ students.

Q: Why does the proposed funding prioritize the Primary School, THES, and the High School? What about the Middle School?

A: We look at the district holistically to determine where a specific injection of funds will prevent the most long-term academic damage. Right now, data dictates that early literacy intervention (Primary and THES) is our most urgent academic vulnerability. Catching reading gaps early prevents compound struggles in middle and high school. At the High School level, restoring leadership and scheduling flexibility ensures students can access the credits they need to graduate. The Middle School remains a priority, and their foundational needs are currently stabilized within our existing operating budget.

Athletics & Extracurriculars

Q: The district cut several athletic programs recently. Why isn't this new money being used to bring those sports back?

A: We deeply feel the loss of these programs and know how vital they are to our students' physical and mental well-being, as well as our community spirit. However, as a public school district, our foundational, statutory mandate is academic instruction. When we face severe budget constraints, we must secure the academic core—like reading interventions and graduation requirements—before we can fund extracurriculars. Restoring sports remains a long-term goal, but we cannot legally or ethically fund them while critical academic interventions remain understaffed.

Q: You mentioned having over \$280,000 in savings for Fiscal Year 2028. Why can't we use that money now to save our sports?

A: We cannot use those specific funds for sports because it is against state law. The funds in question are Massachusetts Special Education Circuit Breaker funds. The state strictly mandates that these dollars can only be applied toward special education out-of-district tuitions and related mandated services. Moving them into the general operating budget to fund athletics, or even general education teachers, is legally prohibited.

Q: When will athletic programs be fully restored?

A: We cannot provide a definitive timeline until we see a structural shift in our year-over-year revenue. We will continue to explore grants, community partnerships, and alternative funding models, but relying on the district's general operating budget for a full restoration will require a larger, sustained increase in district funding beyond this fall's anticipated state revenue.

Next Steps

Q: How can parents access the research mentioned regarding reading specialists vs. class sizes?

A: We believe in complete transparency. Our curriculum office has compiled a summary of the data and case studies that guided this decision. You can review the literature by contacting the Director of Teaching and Learning, Dr. Sarfde's office directly.

Q: How can I make my voice heard regarding the November Special Town Meeting?

A: We urge you to attend the Special Town Meeting in November to vote on the final budget allocations.